

The Age, Melbourne, June 7

A Bit More Focus On Apple/Intel... Perhaps

GARRY BARKER, A columnist for the Melbourne daily newspaper, The Age, has reported on wars, political movements, coups and counter coups. But his true calling was Technology. As the Technology Editor, his comments on Apple's move to Intel throw up some interesting comments

So, now that some of the dust is subsiding and the stampeding herds are headed for the bars, may we offer a couple more thoughts on the forthcoming change in processor suppliers at Apple:

1. Jobs used Intel processors in the boxes he built at NeXT, the computer company he founded after he was kicked out of Apple (OK, he lost a palace revolution) in the mid-80s. Some say he was replaced by John Sculley, which is not so, since Jobs was not at the time the CEO. However, return the mind to NeXT. It had Intel inside.

2. NeXT and its Unix-based operating system were bought by Gil Amelio during his brief and inglorious period as Apple's CEO. He also hired Jobs as consultant, which resulted in the departure of Amelio and the rejuvenation, resurrection and resurgence of Apple.

3. NeXT OS is the base on which Mac OS X was built. As Jobs observed at the World Wide Developer conference in San Francisco last night, Mac OS X has always run on Intel processors. It's just that at the time, and so far, Apple used PowerPC a RISC chip designed by a team formed by Apple, IBM and Motorola. Motorola dropped out, although Freescale, a Motorola spin-off chipmaker, still makes the G4s that are in PowerBooks and iBooks.

4. IBM has had big problems improving clock speeds and reducing heat from its G5. Yields were also a problem, causing delays in delivery of Power Mac G5 boxes.

5. Apple needs a 3 GHz PowerBook. Jobs said last night that the PowerPC is unlikely to deliver that kind of performance, and, more importantly, low power drain and low heat output, in time for Apple to remain competitive in the important notebook market. Somewhere around 30 per cent of Macs sold are notebooks; maybe more.

6. With video becoming ever more important to consumer electronics, and with competition looming from devices such as the PlayStation, Xbox, and a heap of stuff already starting to cascade from the mega-factories in China, Apple also needs faster, more powerful computers, of whatever form the designers and engineers next produce.

So, finally, what does it all mean? It is a change of processor. It will require a lot of engineering work, but not so much as you would think. And for the rest of us ... will we notice? I doubt it.

These days it does not matter who makes the chip or how it works. What is important is what it does. Mac OS X will run on the Intel chip. It will still be Mac OS X. Version 10.4 (Tiger) will continue to be upgraded, one supposes, and Version 10.5 (dare we suggest it will be called Leopard—because the story goes the leopard can change its spots (processor)—will be out in a year or so.

All of our much loved features (and the very few that bug us) will be there. Life will go on.

Read more at <http://snipurl.com/fq1h>



CNET.com, June 2

Five Reasons Social Networking Doesn't Work

MOLLY WOOD, SECTION editor at CNET.com, engages in ruthless industry analysis in the form of the Daily Buzz and keeps track of tech interests in the Weekly Buzz Report. Her take on why online networking sites won't work is indeed interesting

The word on the street lately is that social networking is in trouble. Friendster has introduced its for-pay blogging tool as an all-too-ironic money-making scheme. Business networking site LinkedIn started charging for its job listings. Business 2.0 has an article about how the indie music networking site MySpace is, for all intents and purposes, the only successful site.

Social networking is labouring under the inescapable weight of the dot-com curse: you have to find the money. No matter how cool your idea is, it's dead on arrival without an actual business plan. At least, that's the theory. If that's true, though, why has blogging, which seems like a neat idea dependent on interest but without a concrete revenue stream,

managed to not just thrive, but really dominate the Web? Is it really true that free services can't be effective business plans? Or is it possible that—gasp!—social networking isn't really that tenable an idea after all? Here's my list...



1. There's nothing to do there

As Business 2.0 points out, a simple destination site won't cut it. My big beef with Friendster was always, "Well, what would I do there?" Visiting most social networking sites is akin to getting invited to a party where all the cool kids are going, then showing up and finding out there's no food, no drinks, no band...

2. It takes too much time

Yes, I know I can choose where to devote my time, but Orkut, Friendster, and even LinkedIn are interesting but less information rich than news sites, blogs, Google news, or...

3. Traffic alone isn't enough

The reality of the new Web is that traffic alone just doesn't cut it. You can get all the visitors you want to your site, but you can't just blanket the thing with ads and hope to survive.

4. Strangers kind of suck (or, put nicely, the social hierarchy is really not that attractive)

Getting to know people is, frankly, a less attractive proposal than it first seems. Suddenly, you're bombarded with date offers or all-too-frequent postings about the unsavoury or just plain uninteresting habits of the strangers you suddenly know.

5. We already have the Internet

The only lasting argument about social networking is that these networks are a valuable resource if you're adrift in the sea of online information. But the argument's a little thin in a world where search is the king of the hill. If I need information online, I can find it.

Read the full article at <http://snipurl.com/fq1j>